was spent. It is possible that some of the dues on the ships were settled. But yet more money was required for working expenses. Maintenance and repairs for the steamers also loomed large.

To add to these challenges, all was not well with the *Gallia*.

The Galling Condition of the *Gallia*

An uninterrupted daily service was a must if SSNCo was to keep up its advantage in cargo trade. A daily service could not be maintained without a minimum of two steamers. SSNCo prospered when the *Gallia* and the *Lawoe* were both in service, giving a run for BI's money. But this soon changed.

The *Gallia* had been grounded sometime before the political storm tossed SSNCo. While a police report said that it had been lying in Colombo harbour since at least November 1907,[143] SSNCo itself conceded that it had not sailed since September 1907.[144] The Annual Report on the Working of the Native Passenger Ships Act gives specific numbers: the *Gallia* made only nineteen trips carrying 1,952 passengers during 1907–08, plummeting to a sad three and fifty-nine respectively in the next year.[145]

In this context, *The Hindu* report that the *Gallia* was ready to sail for Colombo on 9 April 1908 probably refers to a rare trip.[146] Lying idle for months on end, not only did the *Gallia* not generate revenue, it was also taking on the proportions of a white elephant. For a start, it could not be left unattended: there had to be a watch crew on board which needed to be paid. Signed on for six months, its contract expired in mid-October 1908. The *Gallia*'s captain could do nothing about the crew's daily pleas. Finally, the crew petitioned the principal collector of customs who in turn addressed the captain who could only promise early settlement. As this promise was not kept, the crew approached the master attendant who directed them to the shipping office. Finally, the Agents of SSNCo were contacted who agreed to pay the wages.[147] Apart from the watch crew the regular officers also needed to be paid. At this time the officers were W. Francis, captain and